Wash and Dry

By Shel Silverstein

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: Believe it or not, your dirty laundry can be quite revealing.
ACTOR: Not the kind of dirty laundry that makes tabloid headlines — the real stuff, the dirty clothes that lurk in your hamper and seem to grow into piles of mind-boggling dimensions in no time at all.
ACTRESS: When you walk into George's Laundromat be sure to read the sign.
ACTOR: I provide exactly what I say; nothing more nothing less.
ACTRESS: One thing is for sure, this laundry does not clean your clothes...
TOGETHER: Wash and Dry by Shel Silverstein

Setting: The Laundromat. George sits and waits. Marianne enters with laundry bag.

MARIANNE: *(Entering.)* Good morning. *(She puts bag on counter.)*

GEORGE: Good morning.

MARIANNE: It's a beautiful morning - *(She rummages in purse for ticket.)*

GEORGE: It's in the eye of the beholder. Wash and dry?

MARIANNE: Yes. Thank you. It's a fresh brisk morning. *(Still looking for ticket.)*

GEORGE: *(Weighing.)* You know how many fresh brisk mornings there have been in the world? Millions - hundreds of millions - and what good has it done? Five forty-three.

MARIANNE: Well it's cool and crisp and not a cloud in the sky - all you can see are blue skies - *(She pays.)*

GEORGE: If I can see blue skies it's not a beautiful day - you know what's a beautiful day? When I can't see any skies at all - when those laundry bags are piled so high you can't see the sky at all - that's what I call a beautiful day - *(He takes bag.)*

MARIANNE: Here's my ticket - I usually lose the ticket. I feel very proud of myself for having it.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

GEORGE: *(Reading.)* Twelve-oh-seven - *(She looks around)*

MARIANNE: That's it up there, the blue bag.

GEORGE: All the way up there.

MARIANNE: The blue bag with the rope string. It matches this one.

GEORGE: Well?

MARIANNE: Well? It's mine.

GEORGE: Well, nobody's saying it isn't yours. Who's saying it isn't yours?

MARIANNE: Well, may I have it please?

GEORGE: Sure you can have it. It's yours.

MARIANNE: May I have it *now* - why not now - Well?

GEORGE: Go get it.

MARIANNE: Go get it?

GEORGE: Why not? It's yours, isn't it?

MARIANNE: I should go get it?

GEORGE: Watch your step climbin' up there - don't step on the top rung - it's rickety - I can't be responsible if you step on that top rung.

MARIANNE: Why don't *you* get it?

GEORGE: Ha-ha. That's a very good question. You want a very good answer - I don't get it because I don't *have* to get it - I didn't agree to get it - wash and dry - not wash, dry and get.

MARIANNE: Getting it - is - just part of the service - it's *expected.*

GEORGE: By you.

MARIANNE: By anyone - It's expected that when you pick up your-

GEORGE: Don't expect too much of life - you'll be sorely disillusioned - you're talking to somebody who knows - don't expect a bed of roses.

MARIANNE: A bed of roses? It's just a common courtesy - it's only-

GEORGE: I did not promise wash, dry and courtesy, did I?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARIANNE: Obviously not.

GEORGE: Well then, I'm not guilty of false advertising, am I? Am I?

MARIANNE: You're really not going to get it.

GEORGE: Wash and dry, period. *(He reads newspaper.)*

MARIANNE: Well - I'll tell you something - *(She begins to climb.)* You don't know how to run a business.

GEORGE: You get what you're promised - consider yourself lucky - most of the time we don't even get what we're promised.

MARIANNE: *(Pulling laundry down.)* Oops.

GEORGE: I warned you about that ladder, didn't I? I warned you loud and clear - I said it's rickety.

MARIANNE: I'll tell you something else. I'm not coming back here anymore.

GEORGE: Never say never - We don't know what we'll do - circumstances - change.

MARIANNE: And ... And if I hadn't paid for this in advance, I wouldn't pay for it now.

GEORGE: Oh, I know that - and that's exactly why I collect in advance - *exactly* why.

MARIANNE: And you'd better not have shrunk my blue cotton blouse - *(She rummages through bag.)* I distinctly said - no hot water-

GEORGE: No hot water was used - it's not shrunk.

MARIANNE: It better not be.

GEORGE: I guarantee it.

MARIANNE: *(Pulling blouse out.)* God.

GEORGE: Well-

MARIANNE: It - it's not even –

GEORGE: I told you.

MARIANNE: It hasn't been - *washed* - it's still - it's just like it was when I brought it in

GEORGE: No shrinkage - a promise made, a promise fulfilled - but don't get *used* to that - don't start expecting that in the rest of your beautiful day -

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARIANNE: It's all - they're all - still dirty. These clothes have *not* been washed. You make me climb up and risk my neck to get my own laundry that you forgot to wash -

GEORGE: I didn't forget. You don't stay in business by forgetting.

MARIANNE: You didn't forget? You just did not -

GEORGE: You get what you contracted for.

MARIANNE: What I contracted for? I contracted for dirty clothes? I brought them in here to be washed and dried - I *contracted* for -

GEORGE: *Watched.*

MARIANNE: What?

GEORGE: *Watched* - not washed. Watch and dry.

MARIANNE: *Watched?*

GEORGE: George's *Watch* and Dry. *(Sign.)* You gotta pay attention - They'll rob you blind. They'll take the gold fillings out of your teeth.

MARIANNE: George's Watch and Dry?

GEORGE: They count on the fact that people don't pay attention - they *depend* on that.

MARIANNE: I paid five dollars and forty-three cents to have my clothes *watched?*

GEORGE: And dried.

MARIANNE: But you haven't *washed* them.

GEORGE: I've *watched* them. I've been watching them for five days-

MARIANNE: Why would somebody want to have their clothes *watched?* Why?

GEORGE: Why is a goose not a gander? There's lots of strange people in this town - bizarre people with unusual needs - and desires. I don't ask questions - They want watch and dry, they get watch and dry.

MARIANNE: I did not come here to have my clothes *watched.* I did not pay five dollars and forty-three cents to have my clothes *watched.*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

GEORGE: And dry.

MARIANNE: Of course they're dry. They've never been wet. I paid to - have my clothes *washed - washed.*

GEORGE: You should have taken them to a laundromat.

MARIANNE: I thought this was a laundromat. That's why I –

GEORGE: Marianne - Marianne - don't agitate yourself.

MARIANNE: You know my name?

GEORGE: I'm not like some people. I care. I pay attention. Read the small print - if you don't they'll skin you alive - they'll peel you like a grape.

MARIANNE: *You're* peeling me like a grape - you're charging me-

GEORGE: I'm teaching you - you've got to -

MARIANNE: Teaching me? By charging me five dollars and forty-three cents to *watch* my clothes? You think that's teaching?

GEORGE: If the lesson was free, you wouldn't learn it.

MARIANNE: I assume you're not giving me my money back.

GEORGE: This is not George's *free* Watch and Dry –

MARIANNE: Well, I'm going to the police - directly - I'm going to the Better Business Bureau and they are going to be all over you like a rash. I am not one of those people who suffer in silence. I do not get fleeced silently - I'm not a sheep. I get raped and I *identify* the rapist. I hunt *him* down and see him prosecuted and punished -

GEORGE: I'm only teaching you what they taught me - I'm passing on the information.

MARIANNE: Information? That people will take your money on a technicality - for watching your laundry - what kind of information is that?

GEORGE: It's real information - all the love thy neighbor do unto others - sisters and brothers stuff - that's all *misinfor*mation - you know what they did to me? They guaranteed my color TV - at least I *thought* they guaranteed it - I

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

assumed - I assumed that was what I was paying three hundred and eighty-five dollars for - and then when the tube blew - then and only then did they inform me that it was not a guarantee - but a *warranty* - that's when they told me to read the fine print.

MARIANNE: Your color TV has nothing to do with –

GEORGE: That was the beginning of my education - my transmission was another lesson - my electrical wiring was another lesson - and my re-upholstery - *and* my Blue Cross - oh, they've taught me a lesson or two - That's when I started paying attention - that's when I started passing along the information.

MARIANNE: That's when you started watching clothes.

GEORGE: Yes, as matter of fact.

MARIANNE: For five dollars and forty-three cents.

GEORGE: Two fifty a load - plus tax.

MARIANNE: A load? Of what? What load.

GEORGE: A machine load.

MARIANNE: Which never goes into the machine.

GEORGE: It's a measurement - You've got to pay attention - Because something is a machine load doesn't mean it *gets* into a machine. Are you beginning to comprehend?

MARIANNE: I comprehend that you have charged me five dollars and forty-three cents to watch - my laundry - and there's not proof that you have even watched it. I *am* going to the police - I really am -

GEORGE: Go ahead, go to the police - And try to prove I didn't watch your stupid laundry - and I'll tell you something else, sweetheart - of all the laundry I ever watched, yours was the most bizarre -

MARIANNE: Bizarre? My laundry was - ?

GEORGE: Item - chocolate stains on nightgown

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARIANNE: Chocolate stains?

GEORGE: Or hot fudge - Who am I to say? - I'm no goddamn chemist - and butterscotch stains on nightgown, denoting late night-

MARIANNE: You *looked* through my laundry -

GEORGE: I *watched* your laundry - you want more proof? Item stains on *blouse* - denoting early day dieting and late-night loss of willpower - also sloppy eating, I might add.

MARIANNE: Sloppy eating - you're judging my - ?

GEORGE: Item - wine stains on slacks, denoting heavy drinking and possible alcoholism.

MARIANNE: Alcoholi-

GEORGE: Or *potential* alcoholism - Item - one white capsule - possibly Nembutal - in pocket of -

MARIANNE: Possibly *what?*

GEORGE: Or it might be an aspirin - How would I know? That's for the boys in the lab to figure out.

MARIANNE: What boys? What lab?

GEORGE: That's for me to know and you to find out. If it turns out to be an aspirin, you have my apology - but if it turns out to be a Nembutal - I'd say cut out the booze - It's a dangerous combination. Item - One pair of pantyhose - *one* pair - two weeks' laundry - four sets of sheets and pillowcases and only one pair of pantyhose. Leaving owner's personal hygiene in question.

MARIANNE: You - you count my sheets and my –

GEORGE: And upon two of those sheets - a dried white residue - possibly semen - I say possibly - possibly dried rubber cement - possibly semen - possibly indicating a certain sexual promiscuity -

MARIANNE: I can't believe -

GEORGE: Item - blood stains on underwear and white skirt, denoting unusually heavy

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

menstrual flow and possibly due to recent dilation and curettage. *(Marianne gasps - sobs, whimpers, stammers')* Don't get yourself agitated - learn your lesson - epileptics have to be careful- *fill* your prescription - *(He unfolds it.)* Don't leave it in your pocket - stay on your medication - don't get agitated. Don't spend time with men who give you ... problems.

MARIANNE: How would you like your neck broken? Really - my boyfriend - I could tell him what you're - he's a big guy he is - he could just break your little neck - how would you like that?

GEORGE: How would his wife like that? - Your big guy - *(Takes shirt.)* Eighteen-inch neck, thirty-six sleeve - initials Y.R. - V.R. - Vincent Romo? - Dispatcher control at United? - Eh? - Y.R.? I think we may have the mystery man here.

MARIANNE: Mystery man?

GEORGE: Possibly the donor of said semen - *or* said rubber cement - possibly the reason for said alcoholism - and said compulsive overeating - possibly - of course, if your father or brother's initials are Y.R - then there's no problem - but that is highly doubtful since your mother's initials are R.D. - unless, of course, she married again, in which case -

MARIANNE: *My mother?*

GEORGE: *(Reading letter.)* Mrs. Donovan, 623 Lake Terrace Road, Milwaukee, Wisconsin? You should answer her letters - she would like some news of you - some news - 623 Lake Terrace Road - it sounds like a nice street - they've put in some poplar trees across from the Hanleys' place - but she doesn't think they'll take-

MARIANNE: I know what it says - give it to me - *(She grabs the letter.)* That's my property.

GEORGE: Hey, it's *yours* - you've got a right to it - 623 Lake Terrace Road, I think the zip is four-oh-oh-five - but I could look it up

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARIANNE: You could look it up -

GEORGE: If I wanted to - If I chose to - you don't control the postal service, you know - I can write to whom I choose - I don't need a warrant to write to whom I choose - I'm free to –

MARIANNE: You - You cannot do this - You cannot violate a person's life - by prying into their laundry - Listen, my father happens to be a very prominent attorney in Milwaukee - I happen to know something about the law - do you realize what you're perpetrating? Breach of contract - charging me for services not recei-

GEORGE: W-A-T-C-H - clearly stated - W-A-T

MARIANNE: Invasion of privacy - going through my –

GEORGE: Hey, I *have* to handle - that's part of my

MARIANNE: Slander - accusing me of -

GEORGE: I'm not accusing - *this* is accusing - Item - small white powdery residue in front of blue wool sweater - possibly cocaine - possibly face powder - I'm not a goddamn criminologist - call' em in and we'll settle the question - *Your* property? - Hey, it's none of my business, it's your business - Possibly American Airlines might think it's *their* business - but I –

MARIANNE: Go ahead - tell them - Just *try* to tell them. Tell them I-

GEORGE: I won't tell 'em, I'll show 'em.

MARIANNE: Show them what? - *This - (Grabs it - George shows Polaroids.)* You took ... *Polaroids* ... of my - *(Reaches.)*

GEORGE: Uh-uh - *my* property - to substantiate my claim-that I watched - you question whether I really watched - You cast aspersions on my professional integrity - Okay, I got proof - I watch-

MARIANNE: You are a rotten, vicious - perverted –

GEORGE: I pay attention - the police pay attention - I'm trying to teach you to pay

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

attention - *watch* and dry - *watch* and dry - read the small print. *(Marianne begins to walk out slowly with laundry)* Will I be hearing from your father? Your big boyfriend? Will I be seeing you in court? ... Next Tuesday then.

MARIANNE: Next Tuesday - ?

GEORGE: Before four o'clock - I close at four on Tuesday.

MARIANNE: You think I'd *ever* bring my laundry in here again - to be watched - to be - violation - a breach of contract –

GEORGE: What's legal? What's illegal? *(He fingers vial with cocaine sample - Marianne stops.)* Okay then - *(He takes pencil.)* I'll put you down for an eight-pound load on Wednesday - every Wednesday - *(Marianne bites her lip and leaves.)* You got to read the small print - they'll squeeze you like an orange - Don't think they won't - Don't assume anything - Pay attention, for God's sake - *(He sits back down and opens newspaper. Marianne exits, in shock.)* And let's not wait two weeks on the pantyhose - eh?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shel Silverstein
Book: An Adult Evening with Shel Silverstein
ISBN: 978-0822218739
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY